

FULLY CHARGED

ONE OF THE BEST PREMIUM COMPACT SUVs, THE VOLVO XC40 GETS AN ELECTRIC POWERTRAIN THAT OFFERS ELECTRIFYING PERFORMANCE AND A PRACTICAL RANGE

BY YOGENDRA PRATAP

The XC40 has been one of the best premium compact SUVs not only in our country but also around the world, winning many awards globally. It was also the first car made on Volvo's new-gen Compact Modular Architecture and that meant that it was ready for full electrification from day one.

We drove the pre-facelift cars and were quite amazed at what they offer in terms of performance and dynamics as well as the overall package that is even better than the ICE XC40. As far as the looks and design go, the Recharge is identical to its fossil fuel-powered sibling except for the front end that gets a flat face instead of the grille, some badging and new 19-inch alloys specially made for electric cars. The dimensions of the car are also near-identical and that means the interior space has also not been compromised as the battery pack goes under the floor. Boot space at just over 400 litres is somewhat compromised though at 414 litres, the frunk somewhat makes up for that with an additional 31 litres under the bonnet up front.

Volvo sticks to its clean and minimalist theme with the interiors for the Recharge. There is a large 9-inch vertical touchscreen paired with the 12.3-inch display for the all-digital instrument panel. The infotainment system as well as the car interface are powered by Google's Android. For us Indians who predominantly use Android phones and with almost everyone using Google Maps, this is a big plus.

Motor 2x150kW permanent magnet
Power 406bhp
Torque 660Nm
Range 418km (WLTP)

The best part of the car though is what one cannot see. Hidden under the floor is a 78kWh lithium-ion battery pack that powers two 150kW motors, one on each axle, effectively making it a 4WD vehicle. With both motors working in tandem, the XC40 Recharge has 408bhp of max power on tap combined with 660Nm of peak torque. That gives it sportscar-like performance figures, including a run from 0 to 100kmph of under 5 seconds.

While we have been saying repeatedly that this XC40 is near-identical to ones not bearing the Recharge badge, there are crucial differences—no engine to start so no start button. The electronics switch on when the car is opened and it is ready to go. Just shifting into D and stepping on the accelerator does it. It has a nice balance even while accelerating and even on not the best of tarmacs, a lot of the torque can be used to make a quick getaway despite its over two-tonne kerb weight. The ride, though on the stiff side, is perfect for going fast over not-so-great surfaces, one does notice the weight of the car when it crashes into potholes.

We drove nearly 250km on a mix of city roads and highways with bouts of spirited driving thrown in and still had enough range to do close to another 100km. That is in tune with the claimed WLTP range of 418km certified for the SUV and should be enough for city requirements anywhere in the country. The XC40 was the one compact premium SUV that ticked all the boxes and its electric version, the Recharge, adds a few more ticks to the list and reinforces a few others. ■